

ALESSANDRO SPARACIO, Ph.D.

Research Scientist & Principal Investigator — A*STAR Institute for Human Development and Potential (IHDP)

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WORK EXPERIENCE

Research Scientist — A*STAR Institute for Human Development and Potential (IHDP)

Aug 2023 – Present | Singapore

My work advances mental health research with a focus on cognition, mood and sleep. I design and implement clinical studies where protocols uphold both scientific integrity and operational feasibility, and I develop non-pharmacological, cost-effective interventions intended to reach a broad population, driven by a commitment to health equity. I led a large multi-site mindfulness study published in *Nature Human Behaviour* — the largest of its kind, with 2,239 valid observations across 37 sites — and subsequently developed SOMA, an open, equity-engineered stimulus library now used as shared infrastructure for mechanistic mindfulness research. I currently serve as Principal Investigator on the NMRC-funded REFORM multi-site trial.

Visiting Scientist — Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore

25 May – 12 June 2026 | Milan, Italy

Invited three-week visiting scientist collaboration, extending the SOMA mindfulness infrastructure and the REFORM trial programme into an Italian research network.

- 26 May — Invited seminar, “Advancing Mindfulness Research: From Nature Human Behaviour to Global Scale,” presenting the REFORM multi-site RCT and the SOMA stimulus library.
- 3 June — Planning meeting with the Cattolica team on the Italian translation and cultural adaptation of the SOMA mindfulness library.
- 4 June — Workshop, “How to Use LLMs to Independently Build an Academic Website and Showcase Your Work.”
- 9 June — Informal tutorial on Open Science practices.

Ph.D. Student in Psychology — Université Grenoble Alpes and Swansea University

May 2019 – March 2023 | Grenoble, France & Swansea, Wales

My joint Ph.D. investigated stress regulation processes, examining the evidential value of stress regulation practices such as mindfulness in order to explain better when and why they benefit well-being. I appraised the available evidence in two meta-analyses (the first pre-registered, the second conducted as a Registered Report), and led a multi-site project with 37 universities worldwide and 2,239 participants testing whether single brief mindfulness exercises reduce stress.

Psychologist — University of Milano-Bicocca

Oct 2018 – Apr 2019 | Milan, Italy

Collaborated on the SIDERA B project, helping create a context-aware platform in which smart technologies (e.g., wearable sensors) managed the care path of patients with chronic diseases.

Psychologist — Digital Attitude

Apr 2018 – Oct 2018 | Milan, Italy

Worked on the development of a virtual assistant designed to help people reduce stress and build new digital habits, simplifying their own and their colleagues' work and improving digital mastery.

Temporary Research Fellow — University of Milano-Bicocca

Jan 2018 – Apr 2018 | Milan, Italy

Research on the implications of social interaction inside Virtual Reality, conducting psychological experiments on the effects of social exclusion experienced within VR environments.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Cognitive Sciences, Psychology and Neurocognition — Université Grenoble Alpes & Swansea University

May 2019 – March 2023

M.S. in Social and Occupational Psychology (110/110 cum laude) — University of Milano-Bicocca

Sept 2015 – March 2017

Visiting Scholar — Purdue University

Sept 2016 – Dec 2016 | Indiana, USA

Four months in the United States conducting research and writing my thesis at Purdue University, focusing on social psychology and in particular how individuals react to social exclusion and ostracism.

B.Sc. in Psychological Sciences and Techniques (99/110) — University of Milano-Bicocca

Sept 2012 – Sept 2015

PUBLICATIONS

- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Davies, J. N., Lee, E., Meissner, T., Spiessens, C., ... Eriksson, J. G. (2026). The Standardized Open-source Mindfulness Architecture (SOMA): A modular, equity-engineered stimulus library for mechanistic mindfulness research. *PsyArXiv Preprints*. osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/cp67b_v1 [Preprint; manuscript under review]
- Sparacio, A., Davies, J. N., Lee, E., & Schmitt, J. A. J. (2025). Feasibility and acceptability of a smartphone-delivered mindfulness intervention for stress reduction in adult Singaporeans: Pilot randomized controlled trial. *JMIR Mental Health*, 12, e77793.
- Sparacio, A., IJzerman, H., Ropovik, I., Giorgini, F., Spiessens, C., Uchino, B. N., Landvatter, J., Tacana, T., Diller, S. J., Derrick, J. L., Segundo, J., Pierce, J. D., Ross, R. M., Francis, Z., LaBoucane, A., Ma-Kellams, C., Ford, M. B., Schmidt, K., Wong, C. C., Higgins, W. C., ... Jiga-Boy, G. M. (2024). Self-administered mindfulness interventions reduce stress in a large, randomized controlled multi-site study. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 8(9), 1716–1725. Selected as cover article, Volume 8, Issue 9, September 2024. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-024-01907-7>
- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Jiga-Boy, G., Lağap, A. C., & IJzerman, H. (2023). Stress regulation via being in nature and social support in adults: A meta-analysis. *Collabra: Psychology*, 9(1), 77343.
- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Jiga-Boy, G. M., Forscher, P. S., Paris, B., & IJzerman, H. (2021). Stress regulation via self-administered mindfulness and biofeedback interventions in adults: A pre-registered meta-analysis. *PsyArXiv*. Available via *PsyArXiv*, psyarxiv.com/zpw28/
- Szabelska, A., Dujols, O., Erle, T. M., Sparacio, A., & IJzerman, H. (2021). Towards theory formalization in (social) embodiment: A tutorial. In *Handbook of Embodied Psychology* (pp. 339–356).
- Ropovik, I., Sparacio, A., & IJzerman, H. (2021). The lack of robust evidence for cleansing effects. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 44, e18.

GRANTS

Awarded

National Medical Research Council (NMRC), Open Fund – Young Individual Research Grant (OF-YIRG). S\$314,685.14. Principal Investigator, awarded under the January 2025 call. Project: Building Resilience Across Socioeconomic Contexts: A Multi-Site Study on Self-Administered Mindfulness (SAM) Interventions [REFORM].

PEER REVIEW

- Nature Human Behaviour
- Journal of Social and Personal Relationships

AWARDS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Exchange Extra-EU Scholarship — Università degli Studi di Milano-Bicocca; Purdue University

Sept 2016 – Dec 2016

€2,250 mobility grant for research and training in the United States, awarded under the Extra-EU Exchange Programme supporting thesis preparation and academic training at Purdue University, Indiana.

Mimprendo Italia — National Innovation Challenge, Team Member, “Gambling Over”

2015

Winner of the Rotary Club Padova Est Prize (€2,000) for social impact. Collaborated with entrepreneurs and innovation mentors to develop a wearable bracelet to help reduce slot machine addiction. Finalist project presented in the national competition.

PRESENTATIONS

- Sparacio, A. (2026, November 26–28). The Standardized Open-source Mindfulness Architecture (SOMA). [Accepted oral presentation]. Society of Australasian Social Psychologists (SASP) 2026, Christchurch, New Zealand.
- Sparacio, A. (2026, November 6–7). Hands-on workshop on the SOMA stimulus library: equity-by-design in mental health research. [Invited workshop]. Neuroethics Asia 2026, NUS Centre for Biomedical Ethics, Singapore.
- Sparacio, A. (2026, May 26). Advancing Mindfulness Research: From Nature Human Behaviour to Global Scale. [Invited speaker]. Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milan, Italy.

- Sparacio, A. (2025, August 30). Brief Mindfulness for Real-Life Stress Relief: Evidence from a Multi-Site Study. [Invited speaker]. The Manchester Mindfulness Festival, Manchester, UK.
- Sparacio, A. (2025, January 8). Self-administered mindfulness interventions reduce stress in a large, randomized controlled multi-site study. [Invited speaker]. Global Young Scientists Summit, Singapore.
- Sparacio, A. (2024, November 18). Self-administered mindfulness interventions reduce stress in a large, randomized controlled multi-site study. [Keynote speaker]. 4th International Conference of the Thai Clinical Psychologist Association, Bangkok, Thailand.
- Sparacio, A., IJzerman, H., Ropovik, I., Giorgini, F., Spiessens, C., SAM multi-site team, & Jiga-Boy, G. M. (2022, November 15). A large, multi-site test of self-administered mindfulness in English speakers. [Online talk]. San Jose State University Psychology Department's Psych Forum, San Jose, USA.
- Sparacio, A., IJzerman, H., Ropovik, I., Giorgini, F., Spiessens, C., SAM multi-site team, & Jiga-Boy, G. M. (2022, August 29–31). A large, multi-site test of self-administered mindfulness in English speakers. [Talk]. ESCON Transfer of Knowledge Conference 2022, Milan, Italy.
- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Jiga-Boy, G. M., Forscher, P. S., Paris, B., & IJzerman, H. (2022, February 16–19). Stress regulation via self-administered mindfulness and biofeedback interventions in adults: A pre-registered meta-analysis. [Poster session]. 2022 SPSP Convention, San Francisco, USA.
- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Jiga-Boy, G. M., Forscher, P. S., Paris, B., & IJzerman, H. (2021, September 13–15). Stress regulation via self-administered mindfulness and biofeedback interventions in adults: A pre-registered meta-analysis. [Best Paper Award finalist]. ESCON Transfer of Knowledge Conference 2021, Salzburg, Austria.
- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Jiga-Boy, G. M., Forscher, P. S., Paris, B., & IJzerman, H. (2021, May 26–27). Stress regulation via self-administered mindfulness and biofeedback interventions in adults: A pre-registered meta-analysis. [Flash talk session]. 2021 APS Virtual Convention.
- Sparacio, A., Ropovik, I., Jiga-Boy, G. M., Forscher, P. S., Paris, B., & IJzerman, H. (2021, January 15). Stress regulation via self-administered mindfulness and biofeedback interventions in adults: A pre-registered meta-analysis. [Talk]. Social Cognition Axe Meeting, Grenoble, France.

TEACHING

- Sparacio, A. (2026, June 9). Informal tutorial — Open Science. Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milan, Italy.
- Sparacio, A. (2026, June 4). Workshop — How to Use LLMs to Independently Build an Academic Website and Showcase Your Work. Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milan, Italy.
- Sparacio, A. & Earp, B. D. (2025, 2nd ed.). Workshop — The Replication Crisis in Science and Medicine: A Reproducibility Opportunity for Singapore. Centre for Biomedical Ethics, NUS, Singapore.
- Sparacio, A. & Forscher, P. S. (2020, November). Meta-Analysis. Four-day workshop, Kurt Lewin Institute, Utrecht, Netherlands.
- Sparacio, A. (2020, February 11). Class on the Replication Crisis, L3 students. Grenoble, France.
- Sparacio, A. (2019, December 4). Class on the Replication Crisis, M2 students. Grenoble, France.

TRAINING

- All Groups Responsible Conduct of Research (RCR) — Refresher Course. CITI Program, online (2026).
- Introduction to Bioinformatics and Data Analytics (IBIDA) Programme — Data Analysis and Visualisation with R (2024).
- All Groups Human Subjects Research. CITI Program, online (2023).
- EASP Summer School 2022. Wrocław, Poland.
- MBSR: Mindfulness Based Stress Reduction online course — Christoph Spiessens Coaching Solutions Ltd., Manchester, UK (2022).
- Mindfulness — From Neurobiology to Psychotherapy. Würzburg, Germany (2021).
- Psychological Networks Amsterdam Summer School 2020 — Online Edition, Amsterdam, Netherlands.